multipotent and can act as a repair system of the body, replenishing adult tissues. The red bone marrow is a rich source of adult stem cells.

The most important and potential application of human stem cells is the generation of cells and tissues that could be used for cell based therapies. Human stem cells could be used to test new drugs.

Totipotency (Toti-total) is the ability of a single cell to divide and produce all of the differentiated cells in an organism.

Pluripotency (Pluri-several) refers to a stem cell that has the potential to differentiate into any of the three germ layers-ectoderm, endoderm and mesoderm.

Multipotency (multi-Many) refers to the stem cells that can differentiate into various types of cells that are related. For example blood stem cells can differentiate into lymphocytes, monocytes , neutrophils etc.,

Oligopotency (Oligo-Few) refers to stem cells that can differentiate into few cell types. For example lymphoid or myeloid stem cells can differentiate into B and T cells but not RBC.

Unipotency (Uni- Single) refers to the ability of the stem cells to differentiate into only one cell type.

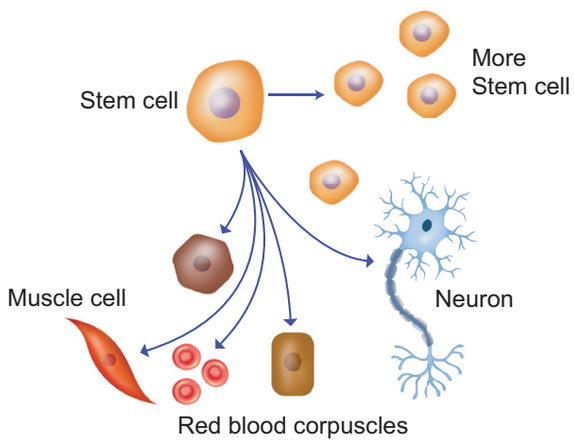


Fig. 10.4 Embryonic stem cells

Stem Cell Banks

Stem cell banking is the extraction, processing and storage of stem cells, so that they may be used for treatment in the future, when required. Amniotic cell bank is a facility that stores stem cells derived from amniotic fluid for future use. Stem cells are stored in banks specifically for use by the individual from whom such cells have been collected and the banking costs are paid. Cord Blood Banking is the extraction of stem cells from the umbilical cord during childbirth. While the umbilical cord and cord blood are the most popular sources of stem cells, the placenta, amniotic sac and amniotic fluid are also rich sources in terms of both quantity and quality.

10.4 Molecular Diagnostics

Early diagnosis of infectious diseases or inherent genetic defects is essential for appropriate treatment. Early detection of the disease is not possible using conventional diagnostic methods like microscopic examinations, serum analysis and urine analysis.These laboratory techniques are indirect and not always specific. Scientists are continuously searching for specific, sensitive and simple diagnostic techniques for diagnosis of diseases. Recombinant DNA technology, Polymerase Chain Reactions (PCR) and Enzyme Linked Immunosorbent Assay (ELISA) are some of the techniques that are reliable and help in early diagnosis. Presence of pathogens like virus, bacteria, etc., is detected only when the pathogen produces symptoms in the patient. By the time the symptoms appear concentration of pathogen becomes very high in the body. However very low concentration of a bacteria or a virus, even when the symptoms of the disease does not appear, can be detected by amplification of their nucleic acid.

ELISA (Enzyme Linked Immunosorbent Assay)

ELISA is a biochemical procedure discovered by **Eva Engvall** and **Peter Perlmann (1971)** to detect the presence of specific antibodies or antigens in a sample

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